

Magpie Alley

No. 106

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

April 2026



A printing office (1600). The printing press is at the back left, with a printer about to pull the handle which lowers the top plate of the press on to the paper, which is resting on top of the freshly-inked type. The compositor's trays are seen on the right.



Compositors (1606):. Note the trays with compartments for the individual letters at the back

Magpie Alley is a very short street about halfway down Bouverie Street, EC4. It is a treasure trove of information about the history of the printing industry in Fleet Street. The alley is a passageway only about 10 ft high and 60 ft. long, with lights recessed into the ceiling for its full length,

The north wall is completely covered with ceramic tiles with pictures of the printers, printing offices, and events in Fleet Street. These pictures can only give you a very faint idea of the wealth of material here - you really need to come and see it for yourself.